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The Inexorable System of Karl Marx

The Manifesto opened with portentous words: “a spectre is haunting Europe—the spectre of Communism. All the powers of old Europe have entered into a holy alliance to exorcise this spectre: Pope and Tsar, Mettemich and Guizot, French Radicals and German police-spies.”

The specter certainly existed: 1848 was a year of terror for the old order on the Continent. There was a revolutionary fervor in the air and a rumble underfoot. For a moment—for a brief moment—it looked as if the old order might break down. In France the plodding regime of Louis Philippe, the portly middle-class king, wrestled with a crisis and then collapsed; the king abdicated and fled to the security of a Surrey villa, and the workingmen of Paris rose in a wild uncoordinated surge and ran up the Red Flag over the Hotel de Ville. In Belgium a frightened monarch offered to submit his resignation. In Berlin the barricades went up and bullets whistled; in Italy mobs rioted; and in Prague and Vienna popular uprisings imitated Paris by seizing control of the cities.

“The Communists disdain to conceal their views and aims,” cried the Manifesto. “They openly declare that their ends can be attained only by the forcible overthrow of all existing social relations. Let the ruling classes

tremble at a Communist revolution. The proletarians have nothing to lose but their chains. They have a world to

The ruling classes did tremble and they saw the threat of communism everywhere. Nor were their fears groundless. In the French foundries the workmen sang radical songs to the accompaniment of blows from their sledge hammers, and Heinrich Heine, the German romantic poet who was touring the factories, reported that “really people in our gentle walk of life can have no idea of the demonic note which runs through these songs/

But despite the clarion words of the Manifesto , the demonic note was not a call for a revolution of communism; it was a cry born only of frustration and despair. For all of Europe was in the grip of reaction compared with which conditions in England were positively idyllic. The French government had been characterized by John Stuart Mill as “wholly without the spirit of improvement and . . . wrought almost exclusively through the meaner and more selfish impulses of mankind” and the French had no monopoly on such a dubious claim to fame. As for Germany, well, here it was, the fourth decade of the nineteenth century, and Prussia still had no parliament, no freedom of speech or right of assembly, no liberty of the press or trial by jury, and no tolerance for any idea which deviated by a hair's breadth from the antiquated notion of the divine right of kings. Italy was a hodgepodge of anachronistic principalities. Russia under Nicholas I (despite the Tsar's onetime visit to Robert Owen's New Lanark) was characterized by the historian de Tocqueville as “the cornerstone of despotism in Europe.”

Had the despair been channeled and directed, the demonic note might have changed into a truly revolutionary one. But as it was, the uprisings were spontaneous, undisciplined, and aimless; they won initial victories and then, while they were wondering what next to do, the old order rocked invincibly back into place. The revolutionary fervor abated, and where it did not, it was mercilessly crushed. At the price of ten thousand casualties, the Paris mobs were subdued by the National Guard, and Louis

Napoleon took over the nation and soon
 Second Republic for the Second Empire. In Belgium
 country decided that it had better ask the king to step
 after all; he acknowledged the tribute by abolishing the
 night of assembly. The Viennese and Hungarian emperors
 were cannonaded from their strongholds, and in Germany
 a constitutional assembly which had been bravely debating
 the question of republicanism broke down into

exchange of letters

country to Frederick William IV of Prussia.
 nominally, that monarch declared that he would accept
 no crown proffered by the ignoble hands of commoners

The revolution was over. It had been fierce, bloody
 but inconclusive. There were a few new faces in Europe
 but the policies were much the same.

But to a little group of working-class leaders who had
 just formed the Communist League, there was no cause
 for deep despair. True, the revolution for which they had
 entertained high hopes had petered out and the radical
 movements pocketed throughout Europe were being more
 ruthlessly hounded than ever before. But all that could
 be regarded with a certain equanimity. For according to
 their understanding of history, the uprisings of 1848 were
 only the small-scale dress rehearsals of a gigantic produc-
 tion that was scheduled for the future, and of the
 eventual success of that awesome spectacle there could
 be not the shadow of a doubt.

The league had just published its statement of objec-
 tives and called it the Communist Manifesto.
 its slogans and its trenchant phrases, the

But for all
 Manifesto had

not been written merely to whip up revolutionary senti-
 ment or to add another voice of protest to the clamor of
 voices that filled the air. The Communist Manifesto had something
 else in mind: a philosophy of history in which a com-
 munist revolution was not only desirable but demon-
 strably inevitable. Unlike the Utopians who also wanted
 to reorganize society closer to their desires, the Com-
 munist Manifesto did not appeal to men's sympathies or to their
 addiction to building castles in the air. Rather, they
 offered men a chance to hitch their destinies to a star

and to watch that star move inexorably across the historical zodiac. There was no longer a contest in which one side or the other ought to win for moral or sentimental reasons or because it thought the existing order was outrageous. Instead there was a cold analysis of which side had to win, and since that side was the proletariat, their leaders had only to wait. In the end, they could not lose.

The Manifesto was a program written for the future. But one thing would have surprised its authors. They were prepared to wait-but not for seventy years. They were already scanning Europe for the likeliest incubator of revolt. And they never even cast a glance in the direction of Russia.

The Manifesto, as everybody knows, was the brain child of that angry genius, Karl Marx. More accurately, it was the result of collaboration between him and his remarkable companion, compatriot, supporter, and colleague, Friedrich Engels.

They are interesting, and, of course, enormously important men. The trouble is, they are no longer just men; Marx the human being is obscured behind Marx the Figure; and Engels behind the shadow of Marx. If we are to judge by a count of worshiping noses, Marx must be considered a religious leader to rank with Christ or Mohammed, and Engels thus becomes a sort of Saint Paul or a John. In the Marx-Engels Institute in Moscow, scholars have pored over their works with all the idolatry they ridicule in the antireligious museums down the street; but while Marx and Engels are canonized in Russia, they are still crucified in much of the world.

They merit neither treatment, for they were neither saints nor devils. Nor is their work either Scripture or anathema. It belongs in the great line of economic viewpoints which have successively clarified, illuminated, and interpreted the world for us, and like the other great works on the shelf, it is neither without flaw nor devoid of merit. The world has been preoccupied with Marx the Revolutionary. But had Marx not lived there would have

been other Socialists and other prophets of a new society. The real and lasting impact of Marx and Engels is not their revolutionary activity, none of which bore too much fruit during their own lifetimes. It is with Marx the Economist that capitalism must finally come to grips, for the final imprint he made on history was his prediction that capitalism must inevitably and necessarily collapse. On that prediction, on that “scientific” prognosis, communism has built its edifice.

But let us see the men.

They were very much opposites in appearance. Marx looked like a revolutionary. His children called him “The Mooi, for his skin was dark and his eyes deep-set and flashing. He was stocky and powerfully built and rather glowering in expression with a formidable beard. He was not an orderly man; his home was a dusty mass of papers piled in careless disarray in the midst of which Marx himself, slovenly dressed, padded about in an eye-stinging haze of tobacco smoke. Engels, on the other hand, would pass for a member of his despised bourgeoisie; tall and fair and rather elegant, he had the figure of a man who liked to fence and to ride to hounds and who had once swum the Rhine River four times without a break.

It was not only in their books that they differed; their personalities were at opposite poles. Engels was gay and observant and gifted with a quick and facile mind; it was said that he could stutter in twenty languages. He had a taste for the bourgeois pleasures in life, including a good palate for wine, and it is amusing to note that although he turned to the proletariat for his amours, he spent much of his time romantically (and unsuccessfully) trying to prove that his working-class mistress, Mary Burns (and later, after her death, her sister, Lizzie), was actually descended from the Scottish poet.

Marx was much more ponderous. He is the German scholar par excellence, slow, meticulous, and painstakingly, even morbidly, perfectionist. Engels could dash off a treatise in no time at all; Marx was always worrying one to death. Engels was fazed only by Arabic with its

four thousand verb roots; Marx, after twenty years of practice, still spoke hideously Teutonic English. When he writes to Engels of the great “chock” which events have caused him, we can almost hear him speak. But for all his heaviness, Marx is the greater mind of the two; where Engels supplied breadth and dash, he provided the depth. . 1

They met, for the second time, in 1844 in Paris and their collaboration begins at this date. Engels had come merely to call on Marx, but they had so much to say to each other that their conversation lasted for ten days. Thereafter there is hardly a product of the one that was not edited or rewritten or at least debated with the other, and their correspondence fills several volumes.

Their paths to that common meeting ground in Paris were widely divergent. Engels was the son of a pietist, Calvinist, narrow-minded father, a manufacturer in the Rhineland. When Friedrich as a young man had shown an incomprehensible taste for poetry, his father had packed him off to Bremen to learn the export business and to live with a cleric: religion and money-making, according to Caspar Engels, were good cures for a romantic soul. Engels had dutifully applied himself to business, but everything he saw was colored by a personality in revolt, a happy-go-lucky personality but one that was incompatible with his fathers rigid standards. He went down to the docks in the course of business, but his observant eye took in not only the first-class accommodations “in mahogany ornamented with gold” but the steerage as well, where the people were “packed in like the paving-stones in the streets.” He began to read the radical literature of his time and by the age of twenty-two he was converted to the ideals of “communism”--a word which then had no very clear definition except insofar as it rejected the idea of private property as a means for organizing society’s economic effort.

Then he went to Manchester to enter his father’s textile business there. Manchester, like the ships in Bremen, seemed to Engels a facade. There were pleasant streets lined with shops and suburbs ringing the city with pleas-

ant villas. But there was a second Manchester as well. It was hidden behind the first and laid out so that the mill-owners never had to see it on their trips to their offices. It harbored a stunted population living in a state of filth and despair, turning to gin and evangelism and doping themselves and their children with laudanum against a life that was hopeless and brutal. Engels had seen similar conditions in the factory towns of his Rhineland home but now he explored Manchester until he knew every last hovel and each ratlike abode. He was to publish his findings in the most terrible verdict ever passed on the world of industrial slums: *The Condition of the Working Class in England in 1844*. One time he talked of the misery of the place to a gentleman friend and remarked that he had never seen so “ill-built a city.” His companion listened to him quietly and then said, “And yet there is a great deal of money made here; good day, sir.”

He was writing now—treatises to show that the great English economists were only apologists for the existing order—and one of his contributions made an especial impression on a young man named Karl Marx who was editing a radical philosophical magazine in Paris.

Unlike Engels, Marx came from a liberal, even mildly radical, family background. He was born in 1818 in Trier, Germany, the second son of a prosperous Jewish family which shortly thereafter adopted Christianity so that Heinrich Marx, an advocate, might be less restricted in his practice. Heinrich Marx was a respected man; he was, in fact, even appointed *Justizrat*, an honorary title for eminent lawyers, but in his day he had joined illegal banquet clubs which drank toasts to a republican Germany, and he had reared his young son on a diet of Voltaire, Locke, and Diderot.

Heinrich Marx hoped that his son would study law. But at the universities of Bonn and Berlin, young Marx found himself swept up in the great philosophical debate of the day. The philosopher Hegel had propounded a revolutionary scheme and the conservative German universities found themselves split wide open over it.

Change, according to Hegel, was the rule of life. Every

idea irrepressibly bred its opposite and the two merged into a synthesis which in turn produced its own contradiction. And history, said Hegel, was nothing but the expression of this flux of conflicting and resolving ideas as they fired now this and then that nation. Change—dialectical change—was immanent in human affairs. With one exception: when it came to the Prussian state, the rules no longer applied; the Prussian government, said Hegel, was like “God walking on earth.

This was a powerful stimulus for a young student. Marx joined a group of intellectuals known as the Young Hegelians which debated such daring questions as atheism and pure theoretical communism in terms of the Hegelian dialectic, and he decided to become a philosopher himself. He might have, had it not been for the action of that godlike state. Marx's favorite professor, Bruno Bauer, who was eager to procure an appointment for him at Bonn, was dismissed for proconstitutional and antireligious ideas (one evidently as bad as the other), and an academic career for young Dr. Marx became an impossibility.

He turned instead to journalism. The *Rheinische Zeitung*, a small middle-class liberal newspaper, to which he had been a frequent contributor, asked him to take on its editorship. He accepted; his career lasted exactly five months. Marx was then a radical, but his radicalism was philosophical rather than political. When Friedrich Engels came respectfully to call on him, Marx rather disapproved of that brash young man brimming with communist ideas, and when Marx himself was accused of being a Communist, his reply was equivocal: “I do not know communism,” he said, “but a social philosophy which has as its aim the defense of the oppressed cannot be condemned so lightly.” But regardless of his disavowals, his editorials were too much for the authorities. He wrote a bitter denunciation of a law which would have prevented the peasants from exercising their immemorial rights to gather dead wood in the forests; for this he was censured. He wrote editorials deploring the housing situation; for this he was warned. And when he

went so far as to say some uncomplimentary things about the T. sar of Russia, the Rheinische Zeitung was suppressed. p

Marx went to Paris to take over another radical journal which was to be almost as short-lived as the newspaper. But his interests were now turned in the direction of politics and economics. The undisguised self-interest of the Prussian government, the implacable resistance of the German bourgeoisie toward anything which might alleviate the condition of the German working classes, the almost caricaturesque attitudes of reaction which characterized the wealthy and ruling classes of Europe—all this had coalesced in his mind to form part of a new philosophy of history. And when Engels came to visit him and the two struck up their strong rapport, that philosophy began to take formal shape.

The philosophy was to take the name of dialectical materialism; dialectical because it incorporated Hegel's idea of inherent change, and materialism because it grounded itself not in the world of ideas, but on the terrain of social and physical environment.

"The materialist conception of history," wrote Engels many years later in a famous tract entitled "Anti-Dühring" (because it was aimed against a German professor named Eugen Dühring), "starts from the principle that production, and with production the exchange of its products, is the basis of every social order; that in every society which has appeared in history the distribution of the products, and with it the division of society into classes or estates, is determined by what is produced and how it is produced, and how the product is exchanged. According to this conception, the ultimate causes of all social changes and political revolutions are to be sought, not in the minds of men, in their increasing insight into eternal truth and justice, but in changes in the mode of production and exchange; they are to be sought not in the philosophy but in the economics of the epoch concerned/' ^

The reasoning is not difficult to follow. Every society,

says Marx, is built on an economic base, is ultimately grounded in the hard reality of human beings who have organized their activities in order to clothe and feed and house themselves. That organization can differ vastly from society to society and from era to era. It can be pastoral or built around hunting or grouped into handicraft units or structured into a complex industrial whole. But whatever the form in which men organize to solve their basic economic problem, society will require a whole superstructure of noneconomic activity and thought—it will need to be bound together by laws, supervised by a government, inspired by religion and philosophy.

But the superstructure of thought cannot be selected at random. It must mirror the foundation on which it is raised. No hunting community will evolve or could use the legal framework of an industrial society, and similarly an industrial community obviously requires an entirely different conception of law, order, and government than does a primitive village. Note that the doctrine of materialism does not toss away the catalytic function and creativity of ideas. It only maintains that thoughts and ideas are the product of environment, even though they aim to change that environment.

Materialism by itself would reduce ideas to mere passive accompaniments of economic activity. That was not Marx's contention. For the new theory was dialectical as well as materialist: it envisaged change, constant and inherent change; and in that never-ending flux the ideas emanating from one period would help to shape another. "Men make their own history," wrote Marx, commenting on the coup d'etat of Louis Napoleon in 1852, "but they do not make it just as they please; they do not make it under circumstances chosen by themselves, but under circumstances directly found, given, and transmitted from the past."

But the dialectical—the changing—aspect of this theory of history did not depend merely on the interplay of ideas and social structures. There was another and far more powerful agent at work. The economic world itself

was changing; the ultimate reality on which the structure of ideas was built was itself constantly in flux.

For example, the isolated markets of the Middle Ages began to lock fingers under the impetus of exploration and political unification, and a new commercial world was born. The old hand mill was replaced by the steam mill under the impetus of invention, and a new form of social organization called the factory came into being. In both cases the ultimate reality of economic life itself changed its form, and as it did, it forced a new social adaptation from the community in which it was embedded.

And once such a change had taken place, it carried with it a whole train of consequences. The market and the factory were incompatible with the feudal way of life—even though they were born amidst it. They demanded a new cultural and social context to go with them. And they helped in that difficult birthing process by creating their own new social classes: the market created a professional merchant class and the factory a proletariat.

But the process of social change was not merely a matter of new inventions pressing on old institutions: it was a matter of new classes displacing old ones. For each society is organized into a class structure, into aggregates of men who stand in some common relationship—favorable or otherwise—to the existing form of production. And social change threatens all of that. As the technical conditions of production change—as factories destroy handicraft industry, for example—the old classes find that their accustomed situation is changing too; those on top may find the ground cut from under them, while those who were on the bottom may be carried higher. We have seen just such an upset of the relative position of social classes in Ricardo's day in England, when the capitalists, riding the wave of the Industrial Revolution, were threatening to usurp the time-honored prerogatives of the landed gentry.

Hence conflict develops. The classes whose position is jeopardized fight the classes whose position is enhanced:

the feudal lord fights the rising merchant, and the guild master despises the young capitalist.

But the process of history pays no attention to likes and dislikes. Gradually conditions change and gradually, but surely, the classes of society are rearranged. Amid turmoil and anguish the division of wealth is altered. And thus history is a pageant of ceaseless struggle between classes to partition social wealth. For as long as the technics of society change, no existing division of wealth is immune from attack.

What did this theory augur for the present? It pointed to revolution—inevitable revolution. For capitalism, according to this analysis, must also consist of a technical base of economic reality and a superstructure of a social class system. And if its technical base was evolving, then necessarily, its superstructure must be subject to increasing strain.

That is exactly what Marx and Engels saw in 1848. The technical base of capitalism—its anchor in reality—was industrial production. Its superstructure was the system of private property, under which a portion of society's output went to those who owned its great technical apparatus. The conflict lay in the fact that the base and superstructure were incompatible.

Why? Because the base of industrial production—the actual making of goods—was a highly organized, integrated, interdependent process, whereas the superstructure of private property was the most highly individualistic of social systems. Hence the superstructure and the base clashed: factories necessitated social planning, and private property abhorred it; capitalism had become so complex that it needed direction but capitalists insisted on a ruinous freedom.

The result was twofold. First, capitalism must destroy itself. The planless nature of production must lead to a constant disorganization of economic activity—to crises and slumps and the social chaos of depression. The system was simply too complex; it was constantly getting out of joint, losing step, and overproducing one good while underproducing another.

Secondly, capitalism would unknowingly breed its own successor. Within its great factories it would not only create the technical base for socialism-mass production—but it would create as well a trained and disciplined proletariat who would be the agent of socialism—the embittered proletariat. By its own inner dynamic, capitalism would produce its own downfall, and in the process, it would nourish its own enemy.

It was a profoundly revolutionary insight into history, not only for what it betokened for the future, but for the whole new perspective it opened upon the past. We have come to be familiar with the “economic interpretation” of history, and we can accept with equanimity a re-evaluation of the past with respect to the struggle, say, of the nascent seventeenth-century commercial classes and the aristocratic world of land and lineage. But for Marx and Engels, this was no mere exercise in historical reinterpretation. The dialectic led to the future and that future, as revealed by the Communist Manifesto, pointed to an inevitable communist revolution which this same dialectic would produce. In somber words the Manifesto proclaimed: “The development of modern industry . . . cuts from under its feet the very foundation on which the bourgeoisie produces and appropriates products. What the bourgeoisie therefore produces, above all, are its own gravediggers. Its fall and the victory of the proletariat are equally inevitable.”

The Manifesto, with its rumbling, inexorable interpretation of history, was not written in Paris. Marx’s career had been brief in that city. He edited a caustic, radical magazine; he again rubbed the sensibilities of the Prussian government, and at its behest, he was expelled from the French capital.

Pie was married now—in 1843 he had married Jenny von Westphalen, who lived next door to him as a child. Jenny was the daughter of a Prussian aristocrat and Privy Councillor, but Baron von Westphalen was nevertheless a humanist and liberal thinker. He had talked to young Marx about Homer and Shakespeare and even told him

about the ideas of Saint-Simon despite their pronouncement by the local bishop as heresy. As for Jenny—she was the belle of the town. Beautiful and with suitors galore, she could easily have made a more “suitable match than the dark young man next door. But she was in love with him and both families smiled their approval. For the Marxes such a marriage would be a not inconsiderable social triumph and for the baron it was, perhaps, a happy vindication of his humanist ideas. One wonders if he would have given his consent could he have foreseen what was to happen to his daughter. For Jenny was to be forced to share the bed of a common prostitute in jail and would have to beg the money from a neighbor to buy a coffin to bury one of her children. In place of the pleasant comforts and the social prestige of Trier, she was to spend the years of her life in two dismal rooms in a London slum, sharing with her husband the calumny of a hostile world.

And yet it was a deeply devoted union. In his dealings with outsiders, Marx was unkind, jealous, suspicious, and wrathful; but he was a devoted husband and father. Later, much later, when Jenny was dying and Marx was ill, this lovely scene was witnessed by her daughter.

Mother lay in the big front room and The Moor lay in the little room next to it. ... I shall never forget the morning when he felt strong enough to get up and go into Mother's room. It was as though they were young again together—she a loving girl and he an ardent youth starting out together through life and not an old man shattered by ill-health and a dying lady taking leave of each other forever.

The Marxes had moved to London in 1849. Expulsion from Paris, four years before, had landed them in Brussels, where they stayed (and the Manifesto was composed) until the revolutionary outbursts in 1848. Then when the Belgian king had secured a firm enough grip on his shaky throne, he rounded up the radical leaders in his capital -and Marx went briefly to Germany.

the PrliT, hl T P a11 °ver aSain* Marx took over the editorship of a newspaper and it was only a matter of time before the government closed it down. He printed the last edition in red-and sought a haven in London

He was now in desperate financial shape. Engels was in Manchester, leading his strange double life (he was a respected figure on the Manchester Stock Exchange), and he supplied the Marxes with a never-ending stream of checks and loans. But the family faced the bitterest poverty, nonetheless. There were, in all,

ve of them, plus Lenchen, the Westphalen family maid who stayed with them, unpaid, all their days.

Maix had no work—except his never-ending stint in the British Museum from ten o'clock every morning until seven o'clock at night. He tried to make a little money by writing articles on the political situation for the New York Tribune, whose editor, Charles A. Dana, was a Fourierist himself and not averse to a few slaps at European politics. It helped for a while, although it was Engels who bailed Marx out by composing many of his pieces for him—Marx meanwhile advising by letter as follows: “Du musst dein war-articles colour a little more.”

When the articles stopped, he tried to get a clerical job with a railway, but was rejected for his atrocious handwriting. Thereafter he pawned what was left to his name, all the family silver and valuables having been sold long ago. At times his want was so intense that he was forced to sit home because his coat and even his shoes were at pawn; on other occasions he lacked the money to buy postage stamps to send his works to the publisher. And to compound his difficulties, he suffered from the most painful boils. When he arrived home one evening after writing in misery all day long in the Museum he remarked, “I hope the bourgeoisie as long as they live will have cause to remember my carbuncles.” He had just composed the terrible chapter of which describes the Working Day.

Das Kapital

There was only Engels to fall back on. Marx wrote him constantly, touching on economics, politics, mathematics,

military tactics, on everything under the sun, but especially on his own situation. A typical excerpt reads:

My wife is ill. Little Jenny is ill. Lenchen has a sort of nervous fever and I can't call in the doctor because I have no money to pay him. For about eight or ten days we have all been living on bread and potatoes and it is now doubtful whether we shall be able to get even that. ... I have written nothing for Dana because I have not had the money to buy newspapers. . . . How am I to get out of this devilish mess? During the past week or so I have borrowed a few shillings and even pence from workers. It was terrible but it was absolutely necessary or we should have starved.

Only the last years were a little easier. An old friend left Marx a small bequest and he never again touched the lower depths of poverty. Engels, too, finally came into an inheritance and left his business; in 1869 he went to his office for the last time and came over the fields to meet Marx's daughter, "flourishing his stick and laughing and singing all over his face."

In 1881 Jenny died; she had buried two of her five children including her only son; she was old and tired. Marx was too ill to go to the funeral; when Engels looked at him he said, "The Moor is dead, too!" Not quite; he lingered for two more years; disapproved of the husbands whom his two married daughters had chosen; grew weary of the bickering of the working-class movement and delivered himself of a statement that has never ceased to bedevil the faithful ("I am not a Marxist," he said one day); and then on a March afternoon, quietly slipped away.

What had he done, in these long years of privation?

He had produced, for one thing, an international working-class movement. As a young man Marx had written: The philosophers hitherto have only interpreted the world in various ways; the thing, however, is to

change it Marx and Engels had given the accolade to the proletariat in their interpretation of history; now

that it should exert its maximum leverage on history.

It was not an attempt crowned with much success. Coincident with the publication of the *Communist Manifesto*, the Communist League had been formed, but it was never much more than a paper organization; the *Manifesto*, which was its platform, was not then even placed on public sale, and with the demise of the Revolution of 1848 the League died too.

It was followed in 1864 with a far more ambitious Organization, the International Workingmen's Association. The International boasted seven million members and was real enough to have a hand in a wave of strikes which swept the Continent and to earn for itself a rather fearsome reputation. But it, too, was doomed to have a brief history. The International did not consist of a tough and disciplined army of Communists, but a motley crew of Owenists, Proudhonists, Fourierists, lukewarm Socialists, rabid nationalists, and trade-unionists who were leery of any kind of revolutionary theory whatsoever. With considerable skill Marx kept his crew together for five years and then the International fell apart; some followed Bakunin, a giant of a man with a true revolutionist's background of Siberia and exile (it was said that his oratory was so moving that his listeners would have cut their throats if he had asked them to), while others turned their attention back to national affairs. The last meeting of the International was held in New York in 1874. It was a lugubrious failure.

But far more important than the creation of the First International was the peculiar tone which Marx injected into working-class affairs. This was the most quarrelsome and intolerant of men, and from the beginning he was unable to believe that anyone who did not follow his line of reasoning could possibly be right. As an economist his language was precise, as a philosopher-historian it was eloquent, as a revolutionary it was scurrilous. He called his opponents "louts," "rascals," even "bedbugs."

Early in his career, when he was still in Brussels, Maix had been visited by a German tailor named Weitling. Weitling was a tried son of the labor movement; he had scars on his legs from the irons of Prussian prisons and a long history of selfless and valiant efforts on behalf of the German workingman. He came to speak to Maix on such things as justice and brotherhood and solidarity, instead he found himself exposed to a merciless cross-examination on the “scientific principles” of socialism. Poor Weitling was confused, his answers were unsatisfactory. Marx, who had been sitting as the chief examiner, began to stride angrily about the room. Ignorance has never helped anybody yet,” he shouted. The audience was over.

Willich was another to be excommunicated. An ex-Prussian captain, he had fought in the German Revolution, and later was to become an outstanding general on the Union side of the American Civil War. But he clung to the “un-Marxist” idea that “pure will” could be the motive power of revolution instead of “actual conditions”; for this notion—which Lenin was one day to prove was not so farfetched after all—he, too, was dropped from the movement.

And the list could be extended endlessly. Perhaps no single incident was more provocative, more prophetic of a movement which was one day to degenerate into an internal witch-hunt for “deviationists” and “counterrevolutionaries” than the feud between Marx and Pierre Proudhon. Proudhon was the son of a French barrelmaker, a self-educated brilliant Socialist who had rocked the French intelligentsia with a book entitled *What Is Property?* Proudhon had answered, Property is Theft, and he had called for an end to huge private riches although not to all private property. Marx and he had met and talked and corresponded and then Marx asked him to join forces with himself and Engels. Proudhon’s answer is so profoundly moving and so frighteningly indicative of the future that it is worth quoting at some length.

What Is Property?

Let us by all means collaborate,” he wrote, “in trying to discover the laws of society, the way in which these

laws work out, the best method to go about investigating them; but, for God's sake, after we have demolished all the dogmatisms *a priori*, let us not of all things attempt in our turn to instill another kind of doctrine into the people. ... I applaud with all my heart your idea of bringing to light all the varieties of opinion; let us have good and sincere polemics; let us show the world the example of a learned and far-sighted tolerance; but simply because we are at the head of a new movement, let us not set ourselves up as the leaders of a new intolerance, let us not pose as the apostles of a new religion—even though this religion be the religion of logic, the religion of reason itself. Let us welcome, let us encourage all the protests; let us condemn all the exclusions, all the mysticisms; let us never regard a question as closed, and even after we have exhausted our last argument, let us begin again, if necessary, with eloquence and irony. On that condition, I shall be delighted to take part in your association—but otherwise, no!"

Marx's answer was this: Proudhon had written a book called *The Philosophy of Poverty*; Marx now annihilated it with a rejoinder entitled *The Poverty of Philosophy*.

The pattern of intolerance was never to disappear. The First International would be followed by the mild and well-meaning Second—which included Socialists of such caliber as Bernard Shaw, Ramsay MacDonald, and Pilsudski (as well as Lenin, Mussolini, and Laval!), and then by the infamous Third, organized under the aegis of Moscow. And yet, the impact of these great movements is perhaps less than the persistence of that narrowness, that infuriating and absolute inability to entertain a dissenting opinion, that autocratic air, and that antipathy for democracy which communism has inherited from its single greatest founder.

Had Marx produced nothing more in his long years in exile than a revolutionary labor movement, he would not loom today so important a figure in the world. Marx was only one of a dozen revolutionaries and by no means the most successful; he was only one of at least that many prophets of socialism and as a matter of fact he wrote

next to nothing about what that new society might be like. His final contribution lies elsewhere: in his dialectical materialist theory of history, and even more important, in his pessimistic analysis of the outlook for a capitalist economy.

“The history of capitalism,” Stalin has written, has entirely confirmed the theories of Marx and Engels concerning the laws of development of capitalist society . . . that must inevitably lead to the downfall of the whole capitalist system.” What were those laws? What was Marx’s prognosis for the system that he knew?

The answer lies in that enormous work (Capital). With Marx’s agonizing meticulousness, it is remarkable that the work was ever finished—in a sense it never was. It was eighteen years in process; in 1851 it was to be done “in five weeks”; in 1859 “in six weeks”; in 1865 it was “done”—a huge bundle of virtually illegible manuscripts which took two years to edit into Volume I. When Marx died in 1883 two volumes remained: Engels put out Volume II in 1885 and the third in 1894. The final (fourth) volume did not emerge until 1910.

Das Kapital—

There are twenty-five hundred pages to read for anyone intrepid enough to make the effort. And what pages! Some deal with the tiniest of technical matters and labor them to a point of mathematical exhaustion; others swirl with passion and anger. This is an economist who has read every economist, a German pedant with a passion for footnotes, and an emotional critic who can write that capital is dead labour, that vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour and who tells us that capital came into the world “dripping from head to foot, from every pore, with blood and dirt.”

And yet one must not jump to the conclusion that this is merely a biased and irascible text inveighing against the sins of the wicked money-barons. It is shot through with remarks which betray the total involvement of the man with his theoretical adversary, but the great merit of the book, curiously enough, is its utter detachment from all considerations of morality. The book describes

with fury, but it analyzes with cold logic. For what Marx has set for his goal is to discover the intrinsic tendencies of the capitalist system, its inner laws of motion, and in so doing he has eschewed the easy but less convincing means of merely expatiating on its manifest shortcomings. Instead he erects the most rigorous, the purest capitalism imaginable and within this rarefied abstract system with an imaginary capitalism in which all the obvious defects of real life are removed, he seeks his quarry. It or if he can prove that the best of all possible capitalisms is nonetheless headed for certain disaster, it is certainly easy to demonstrate that real capitalism will follow the same path, only quicker.

And so he sets the stage. We enter a world of perfect capitalism: no monopolies, no unions, no special advantages for anyone. It is a world in which every commodity sells at exactly its proper price. And that proper price is its value—a tricky word. For the value of a commodity, says Marx (and Smith and Ricardo before him), is the amount of labor it has within itself. If it takes twice as much labor to make hats as shoes, then hats will sell for twice the price of shoes. The labor, of course, need not be direct manual labor; it may be overhead labor which is spread over many commodities or it may be the labor which once went into making a machine and which the machine now slowly passes on to the products it shapes. But no matter what its form, everything is eventually reducible to labor, and all commodities, in this perfect system, will be priced according to the amount of labor, direct or indirect, which they contain.

In this world stand the two great protagonists of the capitalist drama: worker and capitalist—the landlord has by now been relegated to a minor position in society. They are not quite the same protagonists we have met earlier in similar economic tableaux. The worker is no longer the slave to his reproductive urge. He is a free bargaining agent who enters the market to dispose of the one commodity he commands—labor-power—and if he gets a rise in wages he will not be so foolish as to

squander it in a self-defeating proliferation of his numbers.

The capitalist faces him in the arena. He is not a bad fellow at heart, although his greed and lust for wealth are caustically described in those chapters which leave the abstract world for a look into 1860 England. But it is worth noting that he is not money-hungry from mere motives of rapacity; he is an owner-entrepreneur engaged in an endless race against his fellow owner-entrepreneurs; he must strive for accumulation, for in the competitive environment in which he operates, one accumulates or one gets accumulated.

The stage is set and the characters take their places. But now the first difficulty appears. How, asks Marx, can profits exist in such a situation? If everything sells for its exact value, then who gets an unearned increment? No one dares to raise his price above the competitive one, and even if one seller managed to gouge a buyer, that buyer would only have less to spend elsewhere in the economy—one man's profit would thus be another man's loss. How can there be profit in the whole system if everything exchanges for its honest worth?

It seems like a paradox. Profits are easy to explain if we assume that there are monopolies in the system which need not obey the leveling influences of competition or if we admit that capitalists may pay labor less than it is worth. But Marx will have none of that—this is to be pure capitalism which will dig its own grave.

He finds the answer to the dilemma in one commodity which is different from all others. That commodity is labor-power. For the laborer, like the capitalist, sells his product for exactly what it is worth—for its value. And its value, like the value of everything else that is sold, is the amount of labor that goes into it—in this case, the amount of labor that it takes to “make” labor-power. In other words, a laborer's salable energies are worth the amount of socially necessary labor it takes to keep that laborer alive. Smith and Ricardo would have agreed entirely: the true value of a workman is the wage he needs in order to exist. It is his subsistence wage.

So far, so good. But here comes the key to profit. The laborer who contracts to work can only ask for a wage which is his due. What that wage will be depends, as we have seen, on the amount of labor-time it takes to keep a man alive. If it takes six hours of society's labor to maintain a workingman, then (if labor is priced at one dollar an hour), he is "worth" six dollars a day. No more.

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But the laborer who gets a job does not contract to work only six hours a day. That would be just long enough to support himself. On the contrary, he agrees to work a full eight-hour, or in Marx's time a ten- or eleven-hour, day. Hence he will produce a full ten or eleven hours worth of value and he will get paid for only six. His wage will cover his subsistence which is his true value, but in return he will sell the value which he produces in a full working day. And this is how profit enters the system.

Marx called this layer of unpaid work "surplus value." But it is quite devoid of moral indignation. The worker is only entitled to the value of his labor-power. He gets it in full. But meanwhile the capitalist gets the full value of his workers' whole working day, and this is longer than the hours for which he paid. Hence when the capitalist sells his products, he can afford to sell them at their true value and still realize a profit. For there is more labor-time embodied in his products than the labor-time for which he was forced to pay.

How can this state of affairs come about? It happens because the capitalists monopolize one thing—access to the means of production themselves. If a worker isn't willing to work a full working day, he doesn't get a job. Like everyone else in the system, a worker has no right and no power to ask for more than his own worth as a commodity. The system is perfectly equitable and yet all workers are cheated, for they are forced to work a longer time than their own self-sustenance demands.

Does this sound strange? Remember that Marx is describing a time when the working day was long—sometimes unendurably long—and when wages were, by and

large, little more than it took to keep body and soul together. The idea of surplus value may make little sense in a world where the sweatshop is very largely a thing of the past, but it was not merely a theoretical construct at the time that Marx was writing. One example may suffice: at a Manchester factory in 1862 the average workweek for a period of a month and a half was 84 hours! Before the previous 18 months it had been 78.32 hours.

But all this is still only the setting for the drama. We have the protagonists, we have their motives, we have the clue to the plot in the discovery of “surplus value. And now the play is set in motion.

All capitalists have profits. But they are all in competition. Hence they try to accumulate and so expand their scales of output, at the expense of their competitors. But expansion is not so easy. It requires more laborers and to get them the capitalists must bid against each other for the working force. Wages tend to rise. Conversely, surplus value tends to fall. It looks as if the Marxian capitalists will soon be up against the dilemma faced by the capitalists of Adam Smith and David Ricardo—their profits will be eaten away by rising wages.

To Smith and Ricardo the solution to the dilemma lay in the propensity of the working force to increase its numbers with every boost in pay. But Marx has ruled out this possibility. He doesn't argue about it; he simply brands the Malthusian doctrine “a libel on the human race —after all, the proletariat, which is to be the ruling class of the future, cannot be so shortsighted as to dissipate its gains through mere unbridled physical appetite. But he rescues his capitalists just the same. For he says that they will meet the threat of rising wages by introducing labor-saving machinery into their plants. That will throw part of the working force back onto the street and there, as an Industrial Reserve Army, it will serve the same function as Malthus' teeming population: it will compete wages right back down to their former “value” —the subsistence level.

But now comes the crucial twist. It seems as though the capitalist has saved the day, for he has prevented

wages from rising by creating unemployment through machinery. But not so fast. By the very process through which he hopes to free himself from one horn of the dilemma, he impales himself on the other.

For as he substitutes machines for men he is simultaneously substituting nonprofitable means of production for profitable ones. Remember that in this never-never

Whatever a machine will be worth to a capitalist, you can be sure that he paid full value for it. If a machine will yield ten thousand dollars' worth of value over its whole life, our capitalist was charged the full ten thousand dollars in the first place. It is only from his living labor that he can realize a profit, only from the unpaid-for hours of surplus working time. Hence when he reduces the number or proportion of workers, he is killing the goose that laid the golden egg.

And yet, unhappy fellow, he has to. There is nothing Mephistophelean about his actions. He is only obeying his impulse to accumulate and trying to stay abreast of his competitors. As his wages rise, he must introduce labor-saving machinery to cut his costs and rescue his profits—if he does not, his neighbor will. But since he must substitute machinery for labor, he must also narrow the base out of which he gleans his profits. It is a kind of Greek drama where men go willy-nilly to their fate, and in which they all unwittingly cooperate to bring about their own destruction.

For now the die is cast. As his profits shrink, each capitalist will redouble his efforts to put new labor-saving, cost-cutting machinery in his factory. It is only by getting a step ahead of the parade that he can hope to make a profit. But since everyone is doing precisely the same thing, the ratio of labor (and hence surplus value) to total output shrinks still further. The rate of profit falls and falls. And now doom lies ahead. Profits are cut to the point at which production is no longer profitable at all. Consumption dwindles as machines displace men and the number of employed fails to keep pace with output. Bankruptcies ensue. There is a scramble to dump goods

on the market and in the process smaller firms go under.

A capitalist crisis is at hand.

Not forever. As workers are thrown out of work, they are forced to accept subvalue wages. As machinery is dumped, the stronger capitalists can acquire machines for less than their true value. After a time, surplus value reappears. The forward march is taken up again. But it leads to the same catastrophic conclusion: competition for workers; higher wages, labor-displacing machinery; a smaller base for surplus value; still more frenzied competition; collapse. And each collapse is worse than the preceding one. In the periods of crises, the bigger firms absorb the smaller ones, and when the industrial monsters eventually go down, the wreckage is far greater than when the little enterprises buckle.

And then, one day, the drama ends. Marx's picture of it has all the eloquence of a description of Damnation: "Along with the constantly diminishing number of the magnates of capital, who usurp and monopolize all advantages of this process of transformation, grows the mass of misery, oppression, slavery, degradation, exploitation; but with this too grows the revolt of the working-class, a class always increasing in numbers, and disciplined, united, organized by the very mechanism of the process of capitalist production itself . . . Centralization of the means of production and socialization of labour at last reach a point where they become incompatible with their capitalist integument. This integument bursts asunder. The knell of capitalist private property sounds. The expropriators are expropriated."

And so the drama ends in the inevitable overthrow which Marx had envisioned in the dialectic. The system—the pure system—breaks down as it works upon itself to squeeze out its own source of energy, surplus value. The breakdown is hastened by the constant instability which arises from the essentially planless nature of the economy, and although there are forces at work which act both to prolong and to hasten its end, its final -death struggle is inescapable. And if the pure system is unworkable,

what possible hope can there be for the real system, with all its imperfections, monopolies, cutthroat tactics, and heedless profit seeking?

For Adam Smith, the capitalist escalator climbed ever upward, at least as far as the eye could reasonably see. For Ricardo that upward motion was finally stalled by the pressure of mouths on insufficient cropland, which brought a stalemate to progress and a windfall to the fortunate landlord. For Mill the vista was made more reassuring by his discovery that society could distribute its product as it saw fit, regardless of what “economic laws” seemed to dictate. But for Marx even that saving possibility was untenable. For the dialectic told him that the state was only the political ruling organ of the economic rulers, and the thought that it might act as a neutral body, as an impartial third force which might balance the claims of its conflicting members, would have seemed little else but sheer wishful thinking. No, there was no escape from the inner logic, the inexorable development of a system which would not only destroy itself but which, in so doing, would give birth to its successor.

As to what that successor might look like, Marx had little to say. It would be “classless,” of course—by which Marx meant that the basis for an economic division of society based on property would be removed once society owned all the means of production of goods. Just how society would “own” its factories; what was meant by “society”; whether there would or could be bitter antagonisms between the managers and the managed, between the political chieftains and the rank and file—none of this did Marx specify. During a transitional period of “socialism” there would be a “dictatorship of the proletariat”; after that, “pure” communism itself.

Marx, it must be kept in mind, was not the architect of communism. That formidable task would fall to Lenin. *Das Kapital* is the Doomsday Book of capitalism, and in all of Marx there is almost nothing which looks beyond the Day of Judgment to see what lineaments paradise may present.

What are we to make of his apocalyptic argument?

There is an easy way of disposing of the whole thing. Remember that the system is built on value—labor value—and that the key to its demise lies in that special phenomenon called surplus value. But the real world consists not of “values” but of real tangible prices. Marx must show that the world of dollars and cents mirrors, in some approximate fashion, the abstract world that he has created. But in making the transition from a value-world to a price-world, he lands in the most terrible tangle of mathematics. In fact he makes a mistake.

It is not an irreparable mistake and by going through an even worse tangle of mathematics one can make the Marxist equations come out “right”—one can, that is, explain a correspondence between the prices that really obtain in life and the underlying values in terms of labor-time. But the critics who pointed out the error were hardly interested in setting the scheme aright and their judgment that Marx was “wrong” was taken as final. When the equations were finally justified, no one paid much attention. For regardless of its mathematical purity, the Marxian rigmarole is at best a cumbersome and difficult framework and an unnecessarily laborious method of getting at the required understanding of how capitalism works.

But while we might be tempted to toss the whole analysis to one side because it is awkward and inflexible, to do so would be to overlook its worth. Marx, after all, did not strip capitalism down to its barest essentials merely to indulge his bent for abstract argument. He did so because he believed that in the simplicity of a theoretical world the mechanics of the actual world would lie clearly exposed; because he hoped that the very starkness of his model world would highlight tendencies hidden in real life.

And so it did. For all its clumsiness, Marx’s model of the capitalist world seemed to work, to display a kind of life of its own. Given its basic assumptions—the raise en scene of its characters, their motives and their milieu—the situation it presented changed, and changed in a way

that was foreseeable, precise, and inevitable. We have seen what these changes are: how profits fell, how capitalists sought new machinery, how each boom ended in a crash, how small businesses were absorbed in each debacle by the larger firms. But all this was still within the framework of an abstract world: now Marx applied his findings on paper to the real world about him—the actual world of capitalism, he said, must also display these trends.

He called the trends the “laws of motion” of a capitalist system—the path which capitalism would tread over future time. And the astonishing fact is that almost all these predictions have come true!

For profits do tend to fall in an enterprise economy. The insight was not original with Marx, nor do profits fall for the reason he gave—we can dispense with the idea of exploitation contained in the theory of surplus value. But as Adam Smith or Ricardo or Mill pointed out—and as any businessman will vouchsafe—the pressures of competition and rising wages will serve quite as well. Impregnable monopolies aside (and these are few), profits are both the hallmark of capitalism and its Achilles’ heel, for no business can permanently maintain its prices much above its costs. There is only one way in which profits can be perpetuated: a business—or an entire economy—must grow.

But growth implies the second prediction of the Marxist model: the ceaseless quest for new techniques. It was no accident that industrial capitalism dates from the Industrial Revolution, for as Marx made clear, technological progress is not merely an accompaniment of capitalism but a vital ingredient. Business must innovate, invent, and experiment if it is to survive; the business that rests content on its past achievements is not long for this enterprising world. It is interesting to note that recently one large chemical company announced that sixty per cent of its income came from products that were unknown ten years ago; and although this is an exceptionally inventive industry, the relationship between industrial inventiveness and profitability generally holds.

The model showed still two more tendencies for capitalism which have also come to pass. We hardly need document the existence of business cycles over the past hundred years nor the emergence of giant business enterprise. But we might remark on the daring of Marx's prediction. When *Das Kapital* appeared, bigness was the exception rather than the rule and small enterprise still ruled the roost. To claim that huge firms would come to dominate the business scene was as startling a prediction in 1867 as would be a statement today that fifty years hence America will be a land in which small-scale proprietorships will have displaced giant corporations.

It was, all things considered, an extraordinary bit of foresight. And note this: all these changes, vast and portentous as they were, could not have been unearthed purely by examining the world as it appeared to Marx's eyes. For these are historical changes, slow in their unfolding and stretched out over time; as real, but as unnoticeable, as the growth of a tree. It was only by reducing the economic system to a microcosm and then by observing that microcosm in its speeded-up life span that this drift of the future could be apprehended.

It was not, of course, exact. Marx thought that profits would not only fall within the business cycle, which they do, but that they would display a long downward secular trend; this does not appear to have taken place. Marx did not stop to consider that the economic particles with which he played had feelings and volitions and consciences that could also change and that they would not therefore behave with the imperturbable predictability of the particles under a chemist's microscope. But for all its shortcomings—and it is far from infallible, as we shall see the Marxist model of how capitalism worked was extraordinarily prophetic.

But everything that Marx had predicted so far was, after all, innocuous. There remained the final prediction of the model; for as the reader will remember, in the end Marx's "pure capitalism" collapsed.

Let it be said at the outset that this prediction as well cannot be lightly brushed aside. In Russia and Eastern

Europe capitalism has disappeared; in Scandinavia and Britain it has been partially abandoned; in Germany and Italy it drifted into fascism and emerged from its bath of fire in less than perfect health. And while wars, brute political power exigencies of fate, and the determined efforts of revolutionaries have all contributed their share the gum truth is that these changes occurred largely for

the reason Marx foresaw: capitalism broke down.

Why did it break down? Partly because it developed the instability Marx said it would. A succession of business crises compounded by a plague of wars, destroyed the faith of the lower and middle classes in the system. But that is not the entire answer—we too have had our wars and depressions, and capitalism here is very much alive. Something else spelled the difference between survival and destruction: European capitalism failed not so much for economic as for social reasons—and Marx predicted this too!

For Marx recognized that the economic difficulties of the system were not insuperable. Although antimonopoly legislation or antibusiness cycle policies were unknown in Marx's day, such activities were not inconceivable: there was nothing inevitable in the physical sense about Marx's vision. The Marxist prediction of decay was founded on a conception of capitalism in which it was socially impossible for a government to set wrongs aright; intellectually, ideologically, even emotionally impossible. The cure for capitalism's failings would require that a government would have to rise above the interests of one class alone—and that, as Marx's doctrine of historical materialism revealed, was to assume that men could free themselves from the shackles of their immediate economic self-interest.

And it is just this lack of social flexibility, this bondage to shortsighted interest, that weakened European capitalism. For one who has read the works of Marx it is frightening to look back at the grim determination with which so many nations steadfastly hewed to the very course which he insisted would lead to their undoing. It was as if their governments were unconsciously vindicat-

ing Marx's prophecy by obstinately doing exactly what he said they would. When in Russia under the Tsars all democratic trade-unionism was ruthlessly stamped out, when in England and Germany monopolies and cartels were officially encouraged, the Marxist dialectic looked balefully prescient indeed. Until very recently, when one considered that in France or Italy or Greece capitalist governments could not collect taxes they levied on their own business communities, when one inspected the enormous gulf between rich and poor and saw evidence of the total indifference of the former for the latter, one had the uneasy feeling that the psychological stereotypes which Marx cast in his historical drama were all too truly drawn from life.

And it is these very facts which give us the clue as to why capitalism has survived in the United States. We have had our share of reactionaries and revolutionaries. The economic history of the United States contains more than enough exploitation and ugliness. But capitalism here nonetheless evolved in a land untouched by the dead hand or aristocratic lineage and age-old class attitudes. To some degree this resulted in a harsher social climate in America than in Europe, for here we clung to the credo of "rugged individualism" long after the individual had been hopelessly overwhelmed by the environment of massive industrialism, whereas in Europe a traditional "noblesse oblige" existed side by side with its unconcealed class divisions. Yet out of the American milieu came a certain pragmatism in dealing with power, private as well as public; an unstinting encouragement to enterprise, whatever the social origins of its protagonist; and a general subscription to the ideals of democracy that steered the body politic safely past the rocks on which it foundered in so many nations abroad.

It is in these attributes that the answer to Marxian analysis lies. Marx was not so much "wrong" in his economic vision as he was wrong in assuming that his psychological and sociological preconceptions were fixed and unalterable. The economic laws of motion which his model of capitalism revealed may still be visible in Amer-

lean capitalism—indeed, they are—but they are faced with a set of remedies which spring from political and social attitudes quite beyond his imagination.

Some of these remedies arise from new attitudes and values on the part of business itself. The rigid antilabor stance of nineteenth- and early-twentieth-century big business has given way to a characteristically matter-of-fact acceptance of unions by big corporations today. The near-religious opposition to social-welfare policies found among the old exponents of the philosophy of rugged individualism has imperceptibly changed into the recognition (however grudging) that programs of social assistance are inescapable in the environment of twentieth-century urban life. In short, the attitudes of business have proved to be as capable of enlightenment as the attitudes of any other class, including (as Marx himself maintained in the case of “neo-Malthusianism”) the working class.

Equally important, by way of countering the Marxian argument, are changes in the role of government. As we have seen, for Marx a government was inevitably the tool of the ruling class, and as long as that class was openly hostile to the working class, one could hardly expect the government to be otherwise. But in the New World both political and economic attitudes diverged from those of mid-nineteenth-century Europe. On the one hand, while capitalists fought their workers in America, they never quite feared them as did capitalists in Europe. And on the other hand, while government in America was often tinged with class interest, its democratic roots prevented it from ever becoming so tainted that it was no longer capable of taking any action against the wishes of the business community. Thus, capitalism in America developed in a milieu of social consensus that brought radically different results from those envisaged by Marx.

In retrospect we can see that capitalism was capable of developing in many directions, just as communism is today. Marx himself never contended that the underlying structure of the economic system enjoined one and only one kind of legal, political, and social superstructure, but rather that the economic underpinnings rejoined

on the kind of superstructure that might be compatible with them. Thus, capitalism could give rise to societies as different—although 'structurally' similar—as the France of Marcel Proust and the Germany of Thomas Mann, not to mention the United States of Sinclair Lewis and of J. i . Marquand. The tragedy is that for much of the world, and especially for so much of the communist world, the stereotypes of English capitalism of the 1850 s, with its grasping, narrow-minded Manchester millowners and its sodden and bitter working classes, is still taken as the true likeness of capitalism everywhere.

But shorn of its overtones of inevitable doom, the Marxist analysis cannot be disregarded. It remains the gravest, most penetrating examination the capitalist system has ever undergone. It is not an examination conducted along moral lines with head-wagging and tongue-clucking over the iniquities of the profit motive—this is the stuff of the Marxist revolutionary but not of the Marxist economist. For all its passion, it is a dispassionate appraisal and it is for this reason that its somber findings must be soberly considered.

To repeat an earlier statement: it is with Karl Marx the Revolutionary that the world has been preoccupied, with Marxism as an expansive force and an intellectually intolerant one. Certainly that is the immediate concern. And yet it is not with Marx the Revolutionary that capitalism must finally contend. When Khrushchev boasted that communism would "bury" capitalism, it was not military prowess but economic theory that gave him his certitude. In the end the figure who must be proven wrong is Marx the Economist, Marx the finicky scholar who laboriously sought to prove, through the welter of surface distraction, that the essence of capitalism is self-destruction. The answer to Marx lies not so much in pointing out the injustices of communism as in demonstrating that capitalism can continue to evolve and to adapt its institutions to the never-satisfied demands of social justice.